Princess and the Hustler: Characters

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Princess & The Hustler: Characters

A detailed understanding of the characters in Princess & The Hustler and the relationships between them, is essential to understanding key concepts in the play.

Here you will find characters profiles for:

Main characters:

- Princess (Phyllis)
- Wendell
- Mavis
- Wendell "Junior"
- Margot

Other characters:

- Lorna
- Leon

Princess (Phyllis)

Princess

- Phyllis "Princess" James is one of the two title characters in the play:
  - She lives with her mother, Mavis, and her seventeen year-old brother, Wendell "Junior":

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

are labelled with this name in the play suggests it is central to her identity
- Princess' joyous, youthful exuberance is central to the play's optimistic message about celebrating one's cultural identity and femininity
- She becomes strongly associated with the "cupboard world' of 'pageantry":
  - This is part of the domestic setting of the play that she transforms, through her imagination, into a place of joy and celebration

- Princess forms close bonds with Wendell and Lorna following their arrival and successfully encourages Mavis to let them stay
- She experiences discrimination in the play which damages her sense of dignity and worth:
  - At school, Princess' half-sister Lorna, who is mixed race, is invited to a party, while Princess is not (Act 2, Scene 1)
  - After Junior returns home after being harmed in a racially motivated attack, Lorna refuses to hide in safety with Princess, stating that she is "not Black" like Princess but "only half"

- In Act 2, Princess begins to doubt her fantasy of winning the beauty pageant and the "cupboard world" in which that fantasy exists:
  - In Act 2, Scene 1, the 'cupboard world…seems less alive' and is 'somehow subdued'

- At the end of Act 2, the loss of confidence Princess experiences **culminates** in her destroying her "cupboard world" and running away from home:
  - Princess declares: "I am Phyllis. I am Phyllis James", symbolically omitting the title of "Princess" and illustrating a loss of her sense of value (Act 2, Scene 5)
  - She goes to Margot's flat, where Margot discovers her

- By the end of the play, Princess has returned home (Act 5, Scene 3), and later admits that she took Junior's bag of money
  - She intended to use the money to take the family to Weston-super-Mare for her beauty pageant

- At the end of the play, Princess recreates the beauty pageant from the opening scene:
  - This is now more fully realised and involves Wendell, who crowns her the winner (Act 3, Scene 6)

Help me understand

Wendell

Wendell

- Wendell James is father to Phyllis "Princess" and Wendell Junior, whom he had with Mavis years before the play begins, and Lorna, whom he fathered with another woman
- Wendell's character follows a **redemptive arc**, and he symbolises positive change
- Wendell initially embodies the idea of a "hustler" and often articulates ideas equating success with financial gain:
  - He tells Junior that he will become well known in Bristol for making "big money" (Act 1, Scene 6)
  - He tells Mavis that it is only a matter of time before he lands "ar lickle pay packet" (Act 2, Scene 1)

- At the start of the play, he is depicted as irresponsible:
  - He reappears suddenly in Bristol and shows little appreciation of Mavis' efforts to bring up their children, having left her almost a decade earlier
  - He continually alludes his previous life as a "hustler"
  - In Act 1, Scene 6, he leaves his two daughters alone at the docks while he gambles at cards

- Wendell previously arrived to England as a Jamaican immigrant as part of the Windrush generation and had previously served in the British army:
  - He has experienced racism and feels underappreciated for his service as a soldier

- While staying with Mavis, it is unclear whether he is actively looking for work:
  - Junior points this out in Act 2, Scene 5 and Margot in Act 1 Scene 7

- As the play develops, Wendell starts to rekindle his relationship with Mavis and she allows him to play a limited role in her family's life
- In Act 2, tensions between Wendell and Margot increase, as she questions the validity of the bus boycotts
- Throughout the play, Wendell becomes more politically active and plays an increasingly enthusiastic role in protests against the **colour bar** in Bristol
- By the end of the play, Wendell has been successful in his political activism and has become reintegrated into the family:
  - He proposes to re-marry Mavis (Act 3, Scene 4); though she doesn't accept explicitly, she does not refuse:
    - Her description of the role she wants him to play in the family ('they [are] the ones that need you to change…") suggests that she is open-minded to the possibility

Princess' pageant, goes into Princess' "cupboard" room "hand in hand" and "gently places the crown on Princess's head"
    - This perhaps suggests that the has transitioned away from his "hustler" role into a more loving, responsible, family-oriented one

Mavis

Mavis

- Mavis James is initially presented as the formidable **matriarch** of the James family
- Mavis' fiercely protective instincts mean that she is sometimes quick to anger:
    - Her stern first lines in the opening scene, reprimanding both Princess and Junior, are a harsh contrast to the gentle dream world of Princess' imagined beauty pageant (Act 1, Scene 1)
    - She slaps Princess' face in a moment of high stress, when Princess is slow to leave the room following Wendell's abrupt return (Act 1, Scene 2)
    - She threatens to harm Wendell with a knife when he doesn't leave the flat (Act 1, Scene 2)

- Mavis consistently displays strong maternal, caring instincts and prioritises the welfare of her children:
    - At key moments in the play, she provides love and reassurance to Princess, and reminds her that she is "beautiful" and is "free to be anything" (Act 3, Scene 5)
    - She agrees to look after Lorna following Wendell's unexpected arrival

- Mavis is shocked and upset at Wendell's sudden reappearance on Christmas Day in Act 1:
    - She initially refuses to let Wendell stay in her home, agreeing only to look after Lorna until Wendell has found somewhere for them to stay

- Mavis softens by the end of Act 1, allowing Princess to persuade her that they should be allowed to stay
- Throughout the play, Mavis becomes more hopeful:
    - She expresses hope that Wendell might become a better man, and "make good" (Act 2, Scene 4)

Wendell “Junior”

Wendell "Junior"

- Wendell “Junior” James is Princess’ seventeen-year-old brother and the son of Mavis and Wendell “the Hustler”
- Junior acts as a bridge between the adult world of his parents and the imaginative, hopeful infant world of his younger sister
- Junior is passionate about photography:
  - His link with cameras and photography is symbolic: he is an observer of his family’s complex dynamic and unlike Princess, is often sceptical of his father’s relationship with them
  - By the end of the play, he seems to have repaired the relationship with his father and includes him in the family photograph taken in the **penultimate** scene (Act 3, Scene 5)
- Junior becomes more politically active throughout the play:
  - He first hears about protests against the **colour bar** from his friend Leon (Act 1, Scene 7)
  - He later marches with students in support of the Bristol Bus Boycott (which he mentions in Act 2, Scene 1)
- His relationship with his father is strained; he is resentful about his father’s unreliability and absence:
  - He argues with his father in Act 1 and questions the motivations for his return (Scenes 6 and 7)
  - He attempts to pay Wendell to leave the family (Act 2, Scene 5)
- Junior experiences direct racial discrimination during the events of the play:
  - In Act 2, Scene 3, he is the victim of a racially motivated attack while out on a protest march, returning home injured and shaken

Margot

Margot

- Margot is a complex character, who, according to Odimba herself, "clearly loves the family, but she also represents and embodies some of that casual racism that was very much alive at the time"
- As a neighbour and friend, Margot is very caring of Mavis and her children:
  - She claims to Wendell that she "look[s] after" Mavis (Act 1, Scene 7)
  - She plays with Princess and Lorna on a number of occasions and refers to them affectionately as "babbers"

- Margot seems to have an ambivalent relationship with the black community in Bristol:
  - When she first meets Wendell, she sits "very close" to him, "crossing her legs seductively" (Act 1, Scene 5)
  - In a tense exchange with Wendell, she claims to be close enough to Mavis' family to be able "to walk in parts of the city others can't", including "into any church [she] like[s] on Sunday"
  - She is dismissive of the "silly" bus boycott in Bristol, arguing to Wendell that such protests might cause friction with the white community (Act 2, Scene 2)
  - She unwittingly creates friction in Mavis' family by giving Lorna (who is mixed race) a white doll, and telling Lorna that her hair is as pretty as the doll's, causing Princess to feel marginalised

- As Margot expresses disapproval of Wendell and the bus boycotts, distance grows between her and Mavis:
  - In Act 2, Scene 4, Margot asks if she is "no longer welcome" in Mavis' home
  - In the same scene, Margot criticises Wendell and Mavis asks Margot to "stop talking like this"
  - When Margot leaves at the end of that scene, Mavis is uncharacteristically cold towards her and doesn't look up or speak

- The relationship between Margot and Mavis is repaired towards the end of the play after Margot returns Princess after she has run away from home:
  - Margot shows obvious care for Princess after discovering she has run away and cut her own hair (Act 3, scene 2)
  - Mavis is appreciative of Margot's care for Princess and says she is "welcome…any time" (Act 3, Scene 3)
  - Margot is emotional at having her relationship with Mavis restored and is moved to tears

Lorna

Lorna

- Lorna is Wendell's child from a relationship with a woman she met after leaving Mavis
- Lorna embodies vulnerability, having been displaced physically from her home, as well as from her family:
  - She brings out an **empathetic** response from Mavis, who feels an instinct to protect her
- Lorna is mixed race, which prompts Princess to think about her role in society as a black girl:
  - Lorna is treated differently at school to Princess and is invited to a party that Princess is not invited to

Leon

Leon

- Leon is Junior's good friend and a guiding moral voice for Junior:
  - He is the first character to mention to Bristol Bus Boycott (Act 1, Scene 6), as his father is involved in organising protest meetings
  - He encourages Junior to be more respectful towards his father (Act 1, Scene 7)
  - He looks after Princess and/or Lorna on more than one occasion when events arise unexpectedly for the James family

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